

Done By Me—Discovering Strategic Goals and Processes

We are a Peer-to-Peer (P2P) business ecosystem. Our current focus is on matching clients who need skilled workers to perform tasks for them. The tasks are usually of small to medium duration related to household needs and are generally provided by individuals rather than crews or teams.

These are a few example tasks that are common within our ecosystem:

- Carpet Cleaning
- Dog Walking
- Electrical Repair
- Food Catering and Delivery
- Home Appliance Repair (dishwashers, refrigerators)
- Home Cleaning
- Home Repair (general)
- Lawn Mowing
- Landscaping and Gardening
- Plumbing (e.g. unclog drains, repair drips, replace pipes)
- Window Washing (outdoor and indoor)
- Window Repair (replace screens and glass)

Of course we are not limited to those tasks alone. We will support hundreds or potentially even thousands of different kinds of tasks.

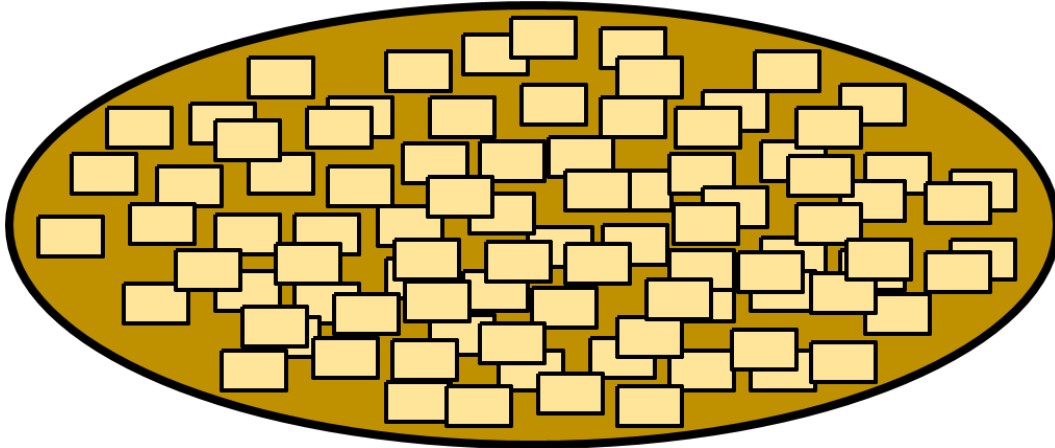
Challenges

We are a funded startup that has been in business for five years. It required time to develop our initial SaaS offering and become a known quantity as a P2P household services network. We finally climbed out of three years of financial losses. Thus, over the past two years our results were break-even and marginally profitable, respectively. This is encouraging, but we haven't accomplished what we sought.

Due to some business misjudgments, our functionality effectively became an auction site where clients propose work, often inaccurately, and could drive down prices by starting bidding challenges between different skilled workers. Of course, our service providers have complained about this and wonder if the network is worth their investments in time and effort to bid on work that will often be less rewarding than without us.

We want to make changes but have experienced the innovator's dilemma: our software system is not well-architected, carefully-designed, or implemented with tactical excellence. Competition has arrived and we can't iterate quickly enough to outpace them.

DoneByMe Legacy



We have to make big changes and do so soon. We've pitched our refined business plan to existing seed investors and new venture funding. These points highlight our vision and business-goal drivers:

1. Services are predicated on fair pricing
2. The pricing service is intelligent and can act as a sort of "auctioneer" to influence higher pricing
3. Users register and declare their role: Client, Doer
4. Users with a Client role are those who propose tasks that they require
5. Users with a Doer role are those who perform the proposed tasks
6. Doers enter the following Profile details:
 - a) Skills
 - b) Task pricing estimates
 - c) Travel radius
 - d) Pricing tolerance (the percentage under fair acceptable for any given time period)
7. Client-Doer collaboration works as follows:
 - a) Client proposes a Task that contains taxonomy-based keywords that specify the hierarchy of required types of work to be done. (This reduces client misinformation.) There is room for the Client to propose a price that is over or under the system's indication of fair, but whether or not a given unfair price is accepted is an algorithmic decision

Keywords example: Windows>Washing>Inside-Outside>Two Story>Extra Tall>Count=37
 - b) The system determines:

Proposed price is fair (or “close enough” to start “auctioneering”)

Pricing service may use its “auctioneer” capabilities to move a low-priced proposal to or near fair pricing

Doers with necessary, qualifying skills

Doers with an open schedule on proposed date/time

c) Client may select/dismiss listed potential Doers that they favor/dislike

d) The skilled/available/favored Doers are notified of the proposed Task, and may accept

e) Client and accepting Doer are matched

Or, if no Doer accepts, the system will determine possible reasons and advise Client of next actions

f) An accepted Task fulfillment is managed to guide the Doer to succeed

g) Reviews by both parties are given, and any arbitration is settled

h) Payment is made

8. There is a high degree of discovery and innovation still to be done, and our commitment is to constant learning in order to achieve success

Team Learning Outcomes

We have chosen a set of tools to use in learning and discovery of areas for understanding innovation. DDD is our primary tool to accomplish this, but we also recognize that complimentary tools are useful.

Example-Driven Specifications to develop usage scenarios in our domain (also known as BDD); requires identifying personas around common usage scenarios that enable us to challenge our strategic and tactical assumptions

Impact Mapping to ensure that we create the right software on purpose and avoid developing any features that are not essential to success

Event Storming to discover the overall business process in a timeline and to encourage inexpensive experimentation to arrive at quick success-or-failure learnings

User Experience (UX) Modeling to show the user (Client and Doer) flows through the system and gain a deeper understanding of predictable or likely user behaviors

The following subsections provide some results from early sessions.

Quick Scenario Experiments

We first sought to understand the kinds of Clients that we will have. It is not always the case that describing user personas is absolutely necessary, because sometimes users of various circumstances and roles will use the software in the same ways. When that is the case you do need to consider the role details, but naming the person and their characteristics may not add

value. The reason to create personas is when it helps with the following learning opportunities that would not be fully realized otherwise:

Discover the general and overall audience for our product

Find the range of personalities that we must satisfy

Solve problems for people that they don't yet know that they have, in such a way that they actually never experience those problems

Understand whether we are in B2C or B2B commerce, or both

Tune our visual content and workflow to specific personalities

Improve marketing strategies

As a result of our discussions we chose to create two personas at opposite extremes:

Julia is not budget constrained and is quite demanding for quality

Michael is budget constrained and thus willing to make tradeoffs to meet his financial limitations

Julia and Michael are described below in more detail.

Writing two quick scenarios based on these personas helped our team to understand a few corner cases that we didn't first imagine, which enabled us to think of outlier features. The outliers, not the normal “happy” engagements, are what drives breakthroughs and the creation of *the best system possible*; software that is *beyond ordinary, truly differentiating*.

Julia is a busy CIO executive. She regularly participates in early-morning meetings with the CEO and others among the management team, but also must drop off her children at a private school prior to reaching the office. There is rarely an opening in Julia's schedule for weeks ahead.

Julia



Driven

Impatient

Passionate

Goals

- Delegate where I can
- Pay others for work I don't want to do myself
- Simplify my busy life

Frustrations

- I have too much to do and not enough time.
- Low quality work
- Finding reliable help

"If I could find reliable people to help me with my everyday tasks, I would have more time to focus on what is really important to me."

Age: 47
Work: CIO
Family: Married, 2 children.
Location: Affluent Neighborhood

Bio

Julia is a busy CIO executive. She regularly participates in early-morning meetings with the CEO and others among the management team, but also must drop her children at a private school prior to reaching the office. When she has something she needs done in her personal life, she has a very specific time limit in mind. Her schedule is more important than cost. She expects quality work and timely responses.

My Preferences in Service

Reliability

Quality Work

Response time

Price awareness

Technology

Mobile Access

Email

Phone

Whatever needs to be done in her personal life, whether it is having dinner ready for her family

or caring for cleaning tasks around her home, she often looks for help from service providers. Gladly for Julia, her high income enables her to afford such services as catering for family meals and managing various household chores.

Scenario: Julia seeks most-qualified Doer for window washing

Given: Julia has submitted a proposal for a task

And: Task Keywords are Windows>Washing>Inside-Outside>Two Story>Extra Tall>Count=43

And: Task is constrained to most-qualified preferred Doer

And: Task is scheduled for Saturday morning starting at 7:00 am

And: Task is priced with the default fair-pricing option plus 20% tip

When: Doers preferred and most-qualified are found from Profiles

And: Doers have open Schedules for Saturday morning starting at 7:00 am

And: Pricing calculates fair-pricing for Saturday morning starting at 7:00 am

Then: Task notifications are sent to the most-qualified preferred Doers; these are staggered by time gaps, per a time-gap policy, from the highest to lowest most-qualified preferred Doer rankings, where the highest ranked Doer receives the notification first

And: Task is matched by one of the most-qualified preferred Doers

Michael is retired after 40 years of post office work and draws a government pension. Permanent damage from a severe knee injury prevents Michael from managing certain household tasks, such as reaching high places by means of a ladder.

Michael



MethodicalPrice ConsciousCautious

Goals

- Get the best value for my money
- Do it myself if possible
- Get help so I can keep my independence

Frustrations

- I can't do what I used to do
- Everything is so expensive today
- I don't have enough money

Bio

Michael is retired from 40 years of post office work and draws a government pension. Although his retirement affords him a lot of time, the permanent damage from a severe knee injury prevents him from managing certain household tasks, such as reaching high places by means of a ladder. As a pensioner, he is always looking for a good deal.

"I worked hard for my pension, I don't want to waste my money. I need to use it carefully."

Age: 72
Work: Retired
Family: Married
Location: Modest home

My Preferences in Service

Reliability

Quality Work

Response time

Price awareness

Technology

Mobile Access

Email

Phone

Although his pension is helpful and covers most of his normal expenses, it doesn't afford him any luxury in his life, which means Michael must save judiciously to go to some football games and maintain his favorite vintage automobile. When he needs any help around his home on work that he is incapable of doing himself, Michael is constantly seeking the best value for the

money he is willing to pay.

Scenario: Michael seeks best-value Doer for window washing

Given: Michael has submitted a proposal for a task

And: Task Keywords are Windows>Washing>Inside-Outside>One Story>Count=16

And: Task is scheduled for Thursday any time of day

And: Task is priced 50% below fair-pricing

When: Doers with Profile pricing tolerances of 50% off fair are not found

And: Pricing calculates fair-pricing at 50% higher than offered

Then: Matching recommends reducing scope or raising offered price

Scenario: Michael resubmits with not-so-unfair price for window washing

Given: Michael has resubmitted a proposal for a task

And: Task Keywords are Windows>Washing>Inside-Outside>One Story>Count=16

And: Task is scheduled for Thursday any time of day

And: Task is priced 25% below fair-pricing

When: Doers with Profile pricing tolerances of 15% (not 25%) off fair are found

And: Pricing “auctioneer” calculates possible-pricing at 18% below offered price

Then: Matching recommends that Michael resubmit proposal for 18% below fair-pricing

And: Task notifications are sent to Doers with 15% pricing-tolerances polling for those that will accept 18% below fair-pricing

During these quick scenario experiments, we realized some additional considerations:

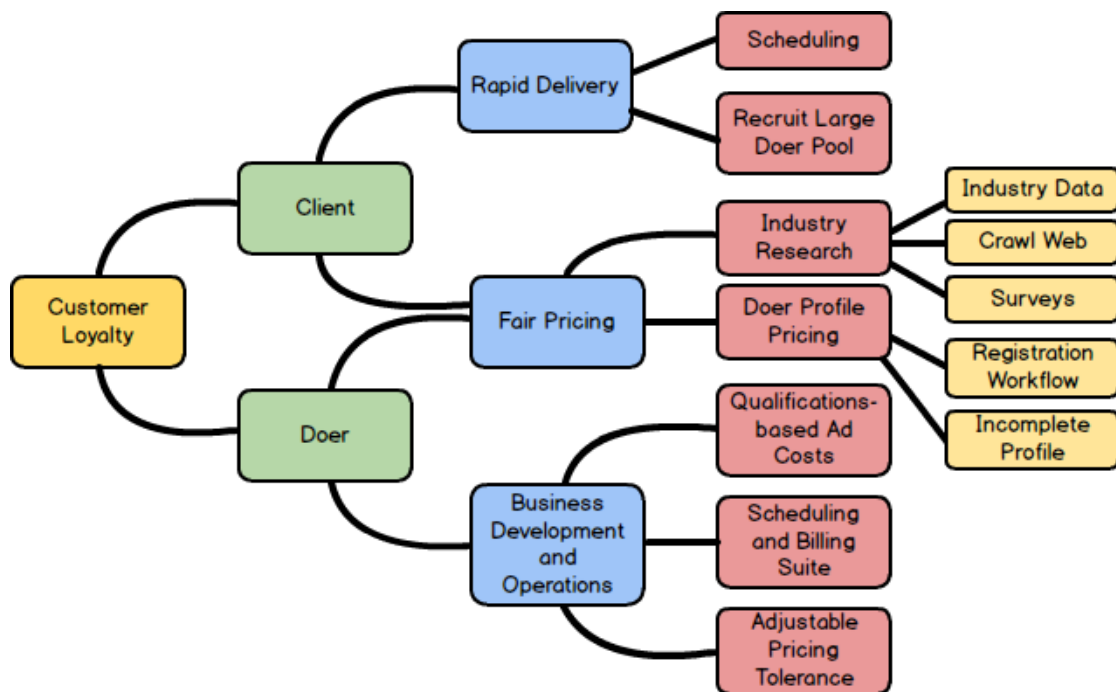
What if Julia is unhappy with the Doer arriving late, the quality of work performed, and lack of clean-up after, and she requests that her 20% tip be withheld?

What if Michael agrees to 18% below fair-pricing, but is choosy about Doers who are willing to work for 18% below fair-pricing?

Impact Mapping

Our learning tools included the use of Impact Mapping to determine the business value that will be delivered. The mapping outcomes have *clear traceability to business goals that are measurable*. The maps help us understand the impacts that need to be made on particular actors (users of our software) to reach our business goals.

One such business goal is *customer loyalty that is measured by returning users*. We will make value-based impacts on both Clients and Doers in order to reach this goal. The following is an early Impact Map that we developed. It can be improved, but it helped us understand our early scope of work.



As seen in this map, we have identified Rapid Delivery and Fair Pricing as impacts that must be made on Clients to gain and retain their loyalty. For Doers, we must also provide Fair Pricing, but we will additionally deliver a set of Business Development and Operations tools.

Our Pricing service team can start working in the areas of the Industry Research deliverable, while our User Identity and Profile team will start on the Doer Profile Pricing deliverable. Here are the deliverables with high-level scenarios:

Pricing Team: Industry Research

- Locate and collect official industry data for job pricing
- Crawl the Web for pricing data by industry
- Send surveys to companies and individual workers requesting participation in exchange for registration with limited free ad placement

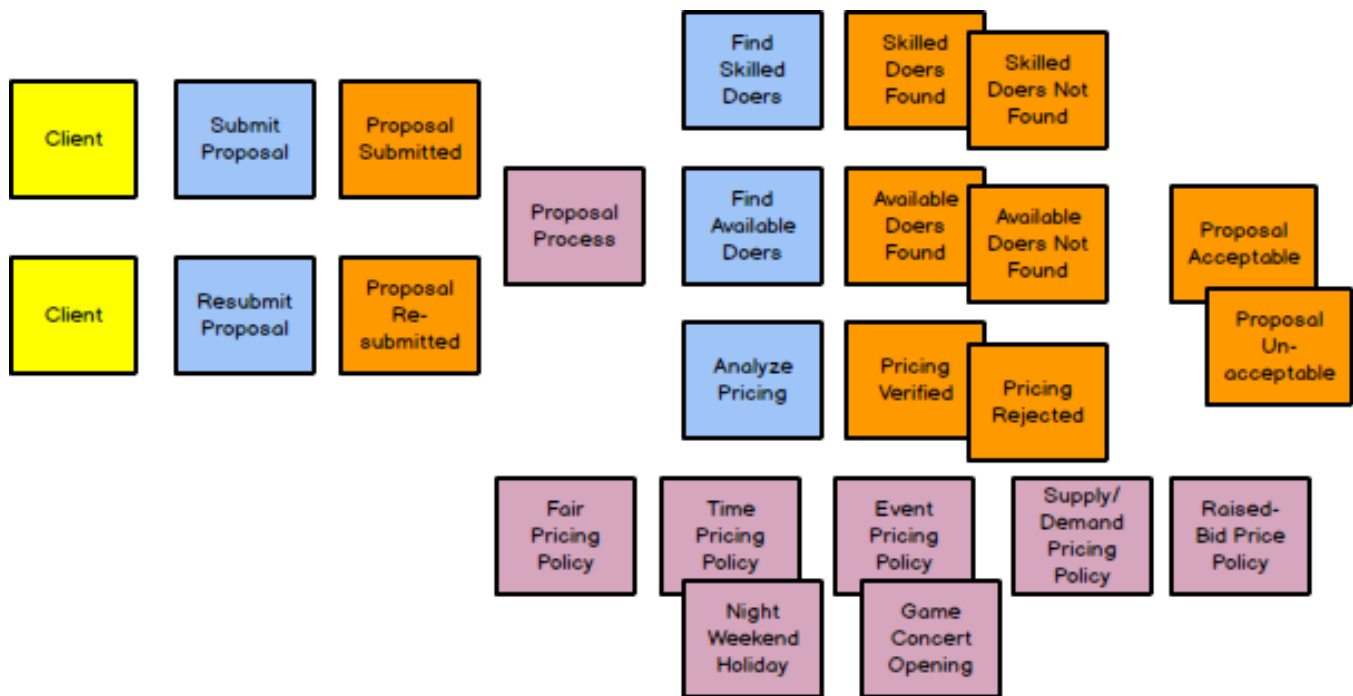
User Identity and Profile Team: Doer Profile Pricing

- When registering, a Doer is asked to provide pricing information for their defined profile skills
- If the Doer does not provide pricing information, the Profile will remind them that they cannot participate as a qualified or preferred Doer, which greatly limits their task winning opportunities

Event Storming

As we worked together on *scenario* creation (above) and developing our Impact Maps, we also employed Event Storming. To begin with we wanted to gain an overall idea of how the

Matching process would work, along with collaboration from our other services.
These are the results from our initial modeling efforts.



This partial model gives us a high-level understanding of our system, modeled in time order from left to right. We are still missing what happens after a proposal is considered acceptable. The unacceptable state takes us back to the Client who can resubmit the proposal with changed expectations. We also captured the names of the various pricing policies that we know now that we will employ. We don't understand the details yet of those implementations, but these policy references serve to call out that we must learn how these will work. Our current understanding is that we will need pricing for normal business hours, as well as during nights, weekends, holidays, when there is some significant event local to the Client, when services supply is high or low, and "auctioneer" strategies for how to deal with Clients to gradually increase their offer price. This deals with how Michael operates.

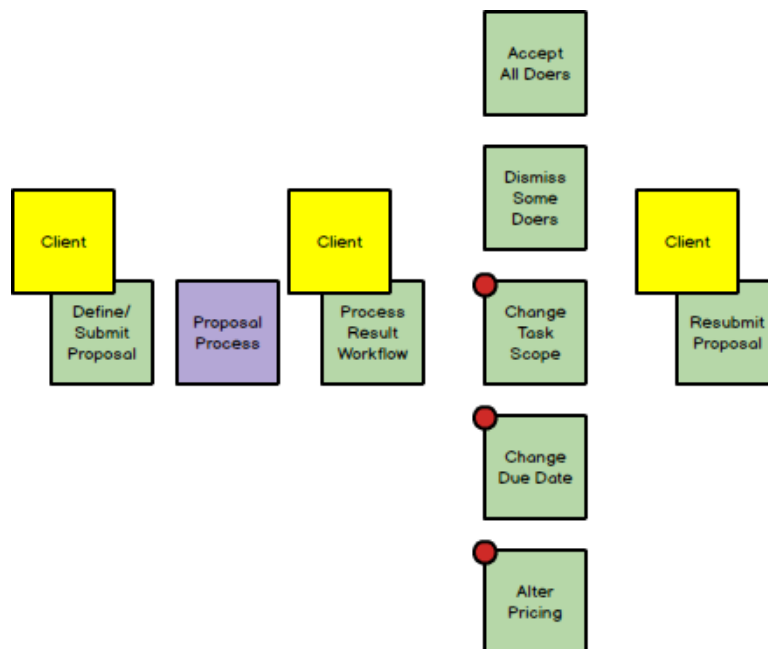
Although limited in scope, this model helped us refine our Scenarios and provide some input into our Impact Maps. Note that we used all of our available tools in an overlapping and mixed fashion to gain insight into our system from various angles.

Details will be driven out in future Scenario authoring and Event Storming sessions, as well as with the use of our two other tools. Our team thinks that the strength of this simple model is in having a big-picture view of part of what our system must do. We learned and we also now know more now about what we don't know. This result puts us in a good position after only about 30 minutes of modeling work with Event Storming.

User Experience Model

We decided to pause our Event Storming session (above). We reached a point where we needed to understand how Clients would interact with the system after the Pricing service indicates that pricing is verified. Will the Client want to see and review the available Doers found from Profile-based skills and further qualified by open Schedule? Will such a review lead to some Doers being dismissed by the Client from their available pool? Will such choices be based on Reviews, or the Doer's skills seem to be missing some important experience, or perhaps the Client disliking the Doer based on their avatar image?

All of these may be factors that will weigh in on a Client's final options. Dismissing some Doers seems like something Michael might decide to do. Recall that Julia doesn't want to be bothered by Doer selection and trusts us to recommend the most capable Doer(s) for her task. So we don't need to include her potential behaviors in this particular case. Let's consider a User Experience (UX) Model and its specific elements to see how we can support Michael's likely choosiness.



This simple UX model helped our team understand what decisions the Client could face within the Proposal Process. In the case of a successful result in the Proposal Process, the Client may decide to accept all found qualified Doers, or the Client may decide for various reasons to dismiss one or more from the recommended candidates.

In the case of an unsuccessful result in the Proposal Process, and depending on the problem, the Client may decide to: (1) change the scope of their Task (offered pricing doesn't fit scope), (2) change the Due Date (no qualified Doers found for the initial due date), and/or (3) alter pricing (pricing was rejected as too low). Note that these three UX elements are marked with a red dot to signify an unacceptable situation that cannot transition to actual matching.

The knowledge gained from this UX modeling exercise was fed back into the other experimental models, producing a deeper understanding of the overall flow of the process and value added to the system as a whole. Of course, this UX model must be expanded past the initial Proposal Process outcomes, and lead to successful matching. This can be performed in the near future as new knowledge is demanded.

Summary

We know that we have made good progress in learning and understanding our overall system. We are also well aware that we have a lot of work ahead of us. The good news is that we love learning and creating great software, and we have the necessary tools to help us reach all of our goals. Here again are the tools we are making use of:

- Scenarios that capture the behavior of our domain models

- Impact Mapping to develop the right software on purpose

- Event Storming to experiment in rapid modeling to get a big-picture and even design-level view of our system

- User Experience Modeling to get a user perspective on how the system works based on predictable or likely user behaviors

Don't forget that implementing source code as part of domain exploration and modeling experimentation is an important step not to be ignored. By challenging all of our assumptions about what we think we know, by creating acceptance tests that push the underlying model enough to know it does what it is supposed to do, we will certainly discover even more business concepts that surface as a matter of course. Uncovering missing knowledge feeds back into our other four tools. This all leads to breakthroughs that deliver differentiating strategic innovation.